CATALYST Centre
Sustainable Transformation

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Business Pilot Project Certificate

presented to

Sophia (Zahra) Chehreghan

for active and outstanding participation in realisation of

Designing an Incentive-Based Circular Rental Model and its Implementation Roadmap for the Future Startup Centre Krefeld

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Designing an Incentive-Based Circular Rental Model and its Implementation Roadmap for the Future Startup Centre Krefeld

Description

The **Circular Rental Model for the Startup Centre Krefeld pilot project** focused on the design, prototyping and validation of an incentive-based rental model for the future Startup Centre Krefeld, located in a former silk factory owned and managed by KREFELD BUSINESS.

The project explored how rental agreements can encourage tenants to adopt circular behaviours - such as time-based circular practices and community engagement - by linking clearly defined commitments to tangible benefits, including service/room fee reduction, increased visibility and shared services.
Over a four-month period, divided into two phases, the project involved research of good practices, co-creation of tenant commitments and incentive mechanisms as well as stakeholder involvement to develop a Circular Rental Agreement Prototype and create the corresponding Implementation Roadmap. While not a final rental model, the Prototype and Implementation Roadmap serve as a practical foundation for future development and adaptation once the Startup Centre becomes operational.

The pilot addressed the challenge of moving beyond conventional space-rental models by embedding circular economy principles into governance and daily practices within an innovation hub. It also provided an applied learning experience in research co-creation, and practical implementation of circular business approaches.

Key Competencies Acquired

- Development of research, critical thinking, creative ideation and collaboration skills
- Application of circular economy principles in real-world business and urban development contexts
- Circular business model design, with a focus on incentive-based rental systems
- Applied research skills, including good-practice analysis and case review
- Co-creation and design-thinking methodologies for developing practical solutions
- Stakeholder engagement and qualitative interviewing for validation and feedback
- Translation of sustainability goals into concrete commitments and governance mechanisms
- Prototype development for policy- and business-oriented tools (Circular Rental Agreement)
- Interdisciplinary teamwork in collaboration with businesses, public stakeholders and mentors
- Critical reflection on implementation, feasibility and scalability of circular solutions

Duration: 4 months

Implementation period:
01 October 2025 – 31 January 2026

Lead Implementing organisation:
The Collaborating Centre on Sustainable Consumption and Production